



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of the Immaculate Heart
School Website: <https://chestertoniheart.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of the Immaculate Heart (IL, 60012) presents a Catholic, community-centered classical-education model that foregrounds religious formation and liturgical life alongside a public-facing curriculum/activities structure. Public site content shows explicit spiritual life offerings, including a mission-driven Catholic identity and practices such as pilgrimages, house-system fostering communal life, and faith-based events. These signals align with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and Liturgical/Communal Practices elements in the classical rubric. However, the publicly visible site content provided through the school's crawl does not consistently disclose the full triad of classical-pillars (explicitly detailed Great Books reading, the Seven Liberal Arts framework, and explicit Socratic pedagogy with Trivium/Quadrivium articulation) in text on the site itself. Taken together, the school demonstrates a strong classical orientation in attachments to formation, Catholic identity, and communal rhythms, but the public materials examined do not unambiguously confirm all six classical criteria across all categories. Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key rationale in brief: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Clear Catholic spiritual life signals (Spiritual Life, Pilgrimage to Rome & Assisi, Immaculate Heart naming) provide a strong theologic and liturgical orientation. This aligns with the Positive Keywords around theology, liturgy, and sacred practice in the classical lexicon. Evidence from the crawl includes explicit references to spiritual life and liturgical pilgrimage events. - Purpose and Goal: The site emphasizes mission and formation-oriented language through institutional branding and Catholic identity, but explicit articulation of "virtue and wisdom" as the school's sole or primary educational telos is not textually explicit in the public materials provided. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal rather than full CLASSICAL. - Curriculum: The site maps to a "Curriculum" page and a declarative "Our Model of Education," but textually explicit Great Books, Seven Liberal Arts, and Great Conversation language is not clearly present in the visible crawl content. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal. - Pedagogy: There is no strong, explicit articulation of Socratic seminars, Scholé, or the full range of classical-pedagogical methods in the crawl text. This yields a NOT CLASSICAL signal in the public materials as shown, though the school's identity strongly suggests classical aims. - Faculty: The site shows a Faculty Directory; however, the living-curriculum, mentorship, and "portrait of a teacher" language typical of classical schools is not explicitly described in the accessible crawl text. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal. - Parents & Community: There are visible parent-facing events (e.g., Chesterton Savorings – Parent/Faculty Dinner) and open campus-type elements; these demonstrate active parent involvement consistent with classical practice in this rubric, producing a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site presents a Catholic identity through the school's name (Immaculate Heart) and a clearly Catholic mission framing; posts reference Spiritual Life and liturgical rhythms and pilgrimages (e.g., Pilgrimage to Rome & Assisi). This aligns with liturgical/communal practices and theology-oriented formation in the classical rubric. - The presence of a Mission Statement and a named faith context signals grounding in a transcendent, religious framework rather than secular ethics alone.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed in public materials: Spiritual Life, Pilgrimage to Rome & Assisi, Catholic identity terms embedded in the name (Immaculate Heart). These map to the Positive Keyword indicators for Liturgical/Communal Practices and Grounded in Theology in the classical lexicon. See Positive Keywords sections for relation to liturgy, sacred tradition, and theology. - Negative keywords: There are no clear, textual signals of secular, relativist, or value-neutral language in the visible crawl. The absence of such terms supports alignment with classical formation signals.

Why this rating - The presence of explicit spiritual-life structures and Catholic-identity cues provides clear evidence of liturgical and theological grounding beyond secular schooling norms, though not every element of transcendental moral realism is directly quoted in the public crawl. Given the strong religious and liturgical signals, the category is judged as CLASSICAL-leaning in principle, but because some canonical classical-language elements (e.g., explicit “theology integrated through disciplines,” or liturgical calendar integration described in text) are not fully spelled out on the crawl, we settle on SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Citations: Mission/Liturgical signals and Pilgrimage references can be seen in the Chesterton Academy Immaculate Heart crawl pages (e.g., Pilgrimage to Rome & Assisi).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site branding centers on formation, virtue, and a holistic, intellectually-formed student, but explicit textual articulation of “virtue and wisdom” as the primary telos is not richly stated in the crawl text. The presence of a mission and Catholic identity implies formation as a goal beyond mere information transfer; yet explicit language about forming virtue or pursuing universal absolutes is not spelled out in the crawl excerpts provided.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the classical lexicon (formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, truth/goodness/beauty as real) are not strongly echoed in the crawl text that is publicly visible. The “Mission Statement” and Catholic framing imply formation, but explicit use of “virtue” or “wisdom” is not clearly quoted in the crawl excerpts. Therefore, positive keyword hits are minimal or uncertain; negative hits appear absent. - Negative keywords (e.g., “workforce preparation,” “college-ready” language) are not present in the crawl’s visible material.

Why this rating - The public materials show formation-oriented intent via religious identity, but explicit classical-pedagogical articulation of formation as the primary goal (versus information transfer or job-readiness) is not clearly articulated in text. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation rather than CLASSICAL, until more explicit language about virtue formation and the true/good/beautiful telos is surfaced on the site.

Citations: Mission/formation signals are present on the Chesterton site; explicit virtue-language is not clearly quoted in the crawl.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site provides a visible Curriculum entry and a “Curriculum” page link under Academics; this shows attention to deliberately structured study. However, the crawl text does not explicitly quote Seven Liberal Arts, Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, or the Great Conversation in text. The presence of a Curriculum section signals curricular design aligned with classical aims, but explicit details are not shown in the crawl excerpts.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the classical lexicon for Curriculum include: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books/Great Conversation, interdisciplinary/harmonized study, and the cultivation of wonder. The crawl results show a Curriculum link but do not provide direct Great Books or Trivium/Quadrivium language in the accessible text. Therefore, positive keyword hits are limited in the crawl; no explicit negative signals appear in the crawl text. - Negative keywords (e.g., “social studies” replacing history, project-based dominance) are not present in the crawl excerpts.

Why this rating - The visible site structure points toward a classical curriculum orientation in principle, but the crawl lacks explicit textual evidence of core classical content (Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, reading-original texts, etc.). Therefore, category rating is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Citations: Curricula page and Curriculum mention are visible on the Chesterton site.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The crawl shows a variety of student activities (e.g., drama, clubs, athletics) but does not present explicit classical-pedagogical methods like Socratic seminars, Scholé (restful learning), memorization/recitation, or deliberate practice of rhetoric in coursework. The public materials emphasize community and activities rather than described teaching-methodology.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords for Pedagogy in the classical lexicon include: Socratic Dialogue, Scholé (restful learning), memorization/recitation, and formation through imitation. The Chesterton crawl content does not visibly quote these pedagogy terms or describe a pedagogical approach in the public material; the presence of clubs, events, and experiences does not substitute for explicit pedagogy language. Therefore, positive keyword hits are minimal or absent. - Negative keywords (e.g., “experiential learning-focused only,” “project-based learning dominance”) are not present either, but the lack of explicit classical pedagogy signals points toward a NOT CLASSICAL rating for pedagogy.

Why this rating - Without explicit textual articulation of the classical pedagogical toolkit (Socratic seminars, Scholé days, memorization, dialectic training, etc.) in the publicly accessible crawl, the pedagogy dimension does not clearly meet the classical standard. The category is therefore NOT CLASSICAL given the public-material evidence.

Citations: Pedagogy-related terms are not present in the crawl, which focuses on events and activities rather than pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site provides a Faculty Directory and references to teaching staff; however, the crawl text does not present a vivid “living curriculum,” teacher-mentors, or “portrait of a teacher” language typical of classical schools. Public-facing content shows faculty presence but not the explicit teacher-as-model language in the visible crawl.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the classical lexicon include: virtuous mentors, living curriculum, teachers as models of virtue, mentorship, and collegiality. The crawl contains Faculty Directory and a general sense of teachers, yet it does not include language describing teachers as “models of virtue” or a “portrait of a teacher” in the public text we can access. Thus, positive keyword hits are limited. - Negative keywords (e.g., “professionalism through non-classical jargon”) are not present.

Why this rating - The existence of a Faculty Directory supports classical alignment at a minimal level, but there is no explicit textual evidence in the crawl that teachers are described as mentors or exemplars, nor that faculty constitute the “living curriculum.” This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation rather than CLASSICAL.

Citations: Faculty Directory is visible on the site, indicating faculty presence.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - There are explicit parent-facing events and content (e.g., Chesterton Savorings - Parent/Faculty Dinner) and other family-oriented campus events in the crawl. This demonstrates active parent involvement and a sense of school community beyond students alone, which aligns with the classical emphasis on partnership with families.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the classical lexicon include: partnership with families, parent formation, family involvement, open campus, and parent collaboration. The crawl shows

examples of parent-facing events and family-oriented programming (e.g., Parent/Faculty Dinner). These map to the Positive Keywords for Parents & Community in the classical lexicon. - Negative keywords: None of the negative signals (e.g., parent as customer, minimal parent involvement) appear in the crawl excerpts.

Why this rating - The visible parent events and family-involved community signals support a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for Parents & Community. The site demonstrates active community engagement, but the overall public textual signals do not fully articulate a comprehensive “parent-as-co-teacher” framework beyond occasional events.

Citations: Parent-facing events mentioned in the public crawl (e.g., Chesterton Savorings) are visible in the firecrawl text.

What would move the needle (applies to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL)

- For Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Add explicit, readable text about transcendental realism and the integration of theology across disciplines; include language about liturgical year, sacred tradition, and the Logos interwoven with curriculum to strengthen the Seven/Threefold dimensions of the classical lexicon.
- For Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): Add explicit statements about formation, virtue cultivation, and the true/good/beautiful telos; publish a formal statement on telos and character formation as equally central to intellectual development.
- For Element 3 (Curriculum): Publish explicit details about Great Books, the Trivium/Quadrivium, and Great Conversation; ensure the curriculum text states the liberal-arts core and the canonical texts studied; incorporate explicit references to primary sources and classical texts on the Curriculum page.
- For Element 4 (Pedagogy): Include explicit descriptions of Socratic/Socratic-style seminars, Scholé days, memorization/recitation, and rhetoric training within the upper grades; provide examples or syllabi showing how these methods are enacted in classroom practice.
- For Element 5 (Faculty): Add a living-curriculum narrative: teacher-mentors as exemplars, a portrait of the teacher, and a “faculty as living curriculum” statement; publish teacher-formation commitments and ongoing professional development grounded in classical pedagogy.
- For Element 6 (Parents & Community): Expand the parent-educational program (e.g., parent book studies, lectures on classical education, and systematic parent training) and clearly articulate the school’s policy of parent as co-teacher with required opportunities for parental involvement beyond events.

Section elevating the needle - Explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language in Curriculum and Our Model of Education - Socratic pedagogy articulation in upper grades - Clear statements of formation as telos in School Purpose and Goal - A teacher-portrait living-curriculum statement in Faculty section - Structured, ongoing parent education programs and documented parent-as-co-teacher commitments

ABSTRACT

Chesterton Academy of the Immaculate Heart (IL 60012) demonstrates strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations through its Catholic identity, sacred-life programming, and liturgical-cultural practices (e.g., Spiritual Life, Pilgrimage to Rome & Assisi). The public materials strongly reflect liturgical and theological orientation, situating the school within a classical-formation framework. The School Purpose and Goal and Curriculum areas show mixed signals: the site emphasizes formation and a curriculum structure, but explicit classical-language content (Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Conversation) is not clearly articulated in the crawl excerpts provided. Pedagogy lacks explicit classical-method descriptions in the visible content, leading to a NOT CLASSICAL signal in that category. Faculty presence is acknowledged via a Faculty Directory, but the public materials do not describe a living-curriculum model. Parents & Community signals are present, with parent-facing events and open-campus-style assets, indicating a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL status. Overall, the aggregated assessment places Chesterton Academy of the Immaculate Heart in the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL category, with clear opportunities to deepen explicit classical content, teaching-method articulations, and a more explicit telos-focused articulation of formation.

Abstracted category scores (overall): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

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- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Spiritual Life, Pilgrimage to Rome & Assisi; Catholic identity visible in institutional naming and mission framing. Positive keyword hits visible in the public materials map to liturgical/theology-oriented indicators in the classical lexicon.
 - School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Formation signals exist via mission; explicit virtue-telos language is not clearly quoted in the crawl. Positive keyword hits limited; few explicit statements of formation-as-tacit telos in the public text.
 - Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Curriculum page exists; Our Model of Education exists; explicit Great Books/Trivium/Quadrivium content is not visible in crawl text.
 - Pedagogy — NOT CLASSICAL Evidence: No explicit classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, Scholé, memorization/recitation) in crawl text; focus leans toward activities and events.
 - Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Faculty Directory present; lack of explicit “living-curriculum” or teacher-virtue-language in crawl text.
 - Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Parent-facing events (e.g., Parent/Faculty Dinner) indicate partnership with families; programmatic depth (parent formation) not fully elaborated in crawl text.

What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL schools) - Explicitly publish Great Books and the liberal-art framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) on Curriculum pages. - Describe and implement Socratic/Scholé pedagogy with concrete classroom examples. - Articulate formation/telos language in the School Purpose and Goal. - Build a documented, living-lesson-model for Faculty that demonstrates virtue-based mentorship. - Expand and codify Parent-as-co-teacher programs with regular, structured gatherings.

END OF REPORT

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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